Essay 1: Macbeth — *Macbeth* by William Shakespeare

Macbeth, the eponymous protagonist of Shakespeare's tragedy, is a figure consumed by ambition — a flaw that transforms a celebrated warrior into a tyrannical murderer. His internal conflict between conscience and desire is the engine driving every major event in the play, making his downfall both a personal and political catastrophe.

From the outset, Macbeth's internal war is visible. Upon hearing the witches' prophecy that he shall be king, he immediately entertains dark thoughts, admitting: *"Stars, hide your fires; / Let not light see my black and deep desires"* (Act 1, Scene 4). He wants the crown, yet he is deeply aware that pursuing it requires abandoning his moral identity. This tension — wanting power while fearing the cost — is the central conflict that sets the plot in motion. It is not the witches who destroy Macbeth; it is his inability to silence his own ambition.

His conscience is most nakedly exposed before Duncan's murder. He hallucinates a floating dagger and questions his own sanity: *"Is this a dagger which I see before me, / The handle toward my hand?"* (Act 2, Scene 1). The vision externalises his guilt — his mind is already fracturing under the weight of what he is about to do. Yet he proceeds, and the murder of Duncan sets off an irreversible chain of violence. Each subsequent killing — Banquo, Lady Macduff and her children — is driven not by cold calculation but by the desperate anxiety of a man who cannot live peacefully with what he has become.

The societal setting of medieval Scotland intensifies Macbeth's flaw catastrophically. In a warrior culture where masculinity is measured by courage and dominance, Lady Macbeth weaponises this expectation against him: *"When you durst do it, then you were a man"* (Act 1, Scene 7). A society that prizes aggression and power provides fertile ground for Macbeth's ambition to metastasise. His flaw is not unique — it is amplified and encouraged by the cultural values surrounding him. Had he lived in a context that celebrated restraint over conquest, his ambition might have remained manageable.

By Act 5, Macbeth is hollowed out. He has lost his wife, his allies, and his sense of self. His famous soliloquy — *"Tomorrow, and tomorrow, and tomorrow / Creeps in this petty pace from day to day"* (Act 5, Scene 5) — reveals a man who no longer sees meaning in life. His nihilism is the final stage of his internal collapse.

Was his fate inevitable? It was — but not because of the witches' prophecy. It was inevitable because Macbeth's fatal flaw, ambition unchecked by moral courage, was never truly confronted, only acted upon. He chose, at every critical juncture, to go further rather than stop. The tragedy lies not in what was done to Macbeth, but in what Macbeth did to himself.

Essay 2: Atticus Finch — *To Kill a Mockingbird* by Harper Lee

Atticus Finch, the quiet moral centre of Harper Lee's *To Kill a Mockingbird*, is a protagonist whose internal conflict is not one of ambition or pride, but of duty versus consequence. He is a man who understands that doing what is right may cost his family dearly — and chooses righteousness anyway. This tension between personal safety and moral obligation shapes every significant development in the novel's plot.

Atticus's conflict is established early when he accepts the assignment to defend Tom Robinson, a Black man falsely accused of raping a white woman in 1930s Alabama. He tells his daughter Scout candidly: *"I couldn't go to church and worship God if I didn't try to help that man"* (Chapter 11). This single decision — made from conviction rather than professional obligation — immediately places his family in danger and divides the community. His internal moral certainty generates the external social conflict that drives the novel forward.

What makes Atticus compelling is his clarity of conscience in a society designed to erode it. Maycomb, Alabama, is a town shaped by deeply entrenched racial hierarchy. When Atticus cross-examines Mayella Ewell and systematically dismantles her testimony, exposing the lie underpinning the entire case, he does so knowing the jury will still convict: *"In our courts, when it's a white man's word against a Black man's, the white man always wins"* (Chapter 23). He proceeds regardless, because for Atticus, moral action is not contingent on the likelihood of success. His flaw, if it can be called one, is an idealism that underestimates the depth of Maycomb's prejudice.

The societal setting of the Jim Crow South is not merely backdrop — it is an active force that exacerbates Atticus's dilemma. His commitment to equality is radical in a community that treats racial inequality as natural law. Bob Ewell spits in his face after the trial, a moment that crystallises how threatening Atticus's decency is to those who depend on the racial order for their sense of dignity. Scout observes: *"Atticus was the deadest shot in Maycomb County in his time"* (Chapter 10) — yet he deliberately lays down that power, choosing law and reason over force. In a violent, hierarchical society, this restraint makes him vulnerable rather than respected.

The attack on Scout and Jem by Bob Ewell on Halloween night is the plot's most dramatic external event — and it flows directly from Atticus's principled stand. His moral courage created an enemy willing to harm children.

Was Atticus's fate inevitable? Unlike Macbeth, Atticus does not fall — but he does not fully win either. Tom Robinson dies, and justice is not served in court. Yet Atticus's ultimate fate — maintaining his integrity intact while the town gradually shifts — suggests his story is one of preventable tragedy. Had even a handful of Maycomb's citizens shared his courage, Tom Robinson might have lived. The tragedy is not Atticus's alone; it belongs to every bystander who chose silence.